

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN THE MARSHALL ISLANDS

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

The struggle in the Marshall Islands is unlike almost any other, because the gravest harm was done long ago by a distant and powerful state, and its consequences are still unfolding, now colliding with a second existential threat. Between 1946 and 1958, the United States detonated sixty-seven nuclear bombs on the atolls of **Bikini and Enewetak**, including the largest weapon it ever tested, and in doing so displaced whole communities, irradiated others, and rendered ancestral homelands unsafe. Decades later the harm endures: contaminated islands to which people cannot return, health effects still unaddressed, promised compensation still unpaid, and, on Enewetak, a cracking concrete dome the Marshallese call the **Tomb**, holding a hundred thousand cubic yards of radioactive waste and now leaking into the lagoon — a dome that rising seas threaten to breach entirely. For the Marshall Islands is also among the lowest-lying nations on earth, on the front line of the climate crisis, so that the old nuclear injustice and the new climate one now meet in a single place. The struggle for justice is unfinished. But a wronged people can turn its injustice into a claim the world hears.

The Marshall Islands works with real tools of justice and accountability. The distinctive lever is the **documented debt of justice** — the unpaid compensation, the unaddressed harm, the contaminated homelands — a claim the nation is owed and the world recognises. The **Compact of Free Association** that binds the nation to the United States is both its dependence and its leverage: the strategic value the nation provides is real, and the compact's terms and renewals are a genuine point of pressure. The **leaking Tomb** on Runit is a concrete, visible accountability the world can see and the responsible party must answer. The **meeting of the nuclear and climate injustice** is uniquely powerful — a small nation wronged twice over, by weapons and by a warming it did not cause. And **international law and the world's movements** stand with the wronged, from the courts to the climate negotiations; protest, petition, and advocacy are lawful. For any new domestic harm, the nation's own **democracy, environmental assessment, and marine and conservation designations** apply as well. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. The responsible party is a powerful ally the nation depends on — for economic assistance, migration rights, and defence — so the leverage is real but constrained by dependence. The United States treats the nuclear matter as settled and has resisted doing more. Much of the harm is already done, and much of the climate threat is beyond the nation's control. And the struggle for justice is unfinished, and may remain so for years. So aim for what these tools can genuinely deliver — the debt of justice pressed and partly paid, the compact leveraged, the leaking dome held to account, the double injustice made a claim the world cannot ignore — through justice, the compact, and the world's conscience, in a struggle a wronged people can carry even against the powerful.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You win here not by stopping a local project but by turning a documented injustice into a claim the world hears and the powerful must answer. Press the debt of justice the nation is owed; use the compact that binds the nation to the United States as leverage as well as dependence; make the leaking Tomb a concrete accountability the world can see; and wield the uniquely powerful meeting of the nuclear and climate wrongs, backed by international law and the world's movements. A small nation wronged by a great power

can, through justice and the world's conscience, hold even the powerful to account.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

The Marshall Islands faces a struggle of justice against a powerful ally, and honesty about that is the first discipline. The responsible party is the very state the nation depends on for assistance, migration rights, and defence, and it treats the nuclear matter as settled; much of the harm is done, much of the climate threat is beyond the nation's control, and justice is unfinished and may stay so for years. So the realistic aim is the debt of justice pressed and partly paid, the compact leveraged, the dome held to account, and the double injustice made a claim the world cannot ignore — through justice, the compact, and the world's conscience.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

The decisions here run through justice, the compact, and the world. The **United States government and Congress** hold the nuclear compensation, the dome, and the compact's terms. The **compact negotiations and renewals** are where the nation's leverage is exercised. **International law and bodies** — the courts, the human-rights and environmental regimes, the climate negotiations — carry the wronged nation's claim. The **world's movements and public** amplify it. And the nation's own **government (the Nitijela) and environmental bodies** govern domestic harms. Map who decides the debt, the dome, and the compact before spending a week on it.

How the Struggle Moves — and Where You Jump In

The justice struggle moves through the debt owed, the dome's accountability, the compact's leverage, and international law. You enter through the documented injustice: the unpaid compensation, the leaking dome, the contaminated homelands, pressed as a claim in the compact negotiations, the international bodies, and the world's conscience. For a new domestic harm, you enter through the nation's own environmental assessment, democracy, and designations. Enter through justice and the compact, and, for domestic matters, the nation's own tools.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the debt: the compensation awarded and unpaid, the harm unaddressed. Follow the compact: the assistance, migration, and defence it provides, and the strategic value the nation gives in return — the leverage. Follow the dome: the radioactive waste, the leaking, the rising seas. Follow the world: the international law and movements that stand with the wronged. The leverage lies in the justice owed, the compact, the dome accountability, and the world's conscience.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

The watchers are international law and bodies, the world's movements and public, the compact's own terms, and — for domestic harms — the nation's government and environmental bodies. A wronged nation's task is to bring the injustice before these watchers, and to make the powerful answer to them.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Marshalllese effort easily wins full justice from a powerful ally that treats the matter as settled, and honesty requires saying so. What the tools can deliver is the debt pressed and partly paid, the compact

leveraged, the dome held to account, the double injustice amplified. The single most decisive move is **turning the documented injustice into a claim the world hears, backed by the compact leverage and international law**, because a small nation wronged twice over commands the world's conscience, and because the compact's terms and renewals give real, if constrained, leverage. The debt owed is the distinctive lever; the compact the leverage; the dome the visible accountability; the double injustice the moral force; the world's movements the reach. The prize is real, though justice is unfinished.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the unpaid compensation, the contaminated homelands, the leaking dome, the climate threat, or a new domestic project. **What debt or accountability applies?** — the justice owed, the dome's answer, the compact's terms. **Where is the leverage?** — the compact negotiations, the international bodies, the world's conscience. **What is the moral force?** — the meeting of the nuclear and climate wrongs. **Is it a domestic harm?** — where the nation's own democracy and assessment apply. Pick the fight where the documented injustice and the compact leverage give the clearest handle.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

Build the case in layers. **Layer one: the injustice** — the nuclear harm, the unpaid compensation, the leaking dome, the contaminated homelands, the climate threat, documented in full. **Layer two: the debt and the leverage** — the justice owed, the compact's terms and the nation's strategic value, the dome's accountability, the international law. **Layer three: the moral force and the reach** — the meeting of the nuclear and climate wrongs, and the international bodies and movements to carry it. A case built on the documented injustice and the compact leverage, made a claim the world hears, is one even a powerful ally must answer.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **injustice record**: the nuclear testing, the displacement, the health harm, the unpaid compensation, the leaking dome, the contaminated islands. Gather the **leverage record**: the compact's terms, assistance, and the nation's strategic value; the international law. Gather the **moral record**: the meeting of the nuclear and climate wrongs. Gather the **reach record**: the international bodies, the world's movements and public. For domestic harms, gather the environmental assessment and designation records. Much of the nuclear and dome record is documented and public.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE COALITION AND THE WORLD'S SUPPORT

The coalition here is national and global. Build with the **affected communities** — the displaced, the irradiated, those who cannot return — whose claim is the heart of it; the **nation's government and negotiators**, who wield the compact leverage; the **international lawyers and human-rights and environmental advocates**; and the **world's movements and public**, moved by the double injustice. Frame the cause around the documented wrong and the meeting of the nuclear and climate injustice — a claim that a wronged people can carry to the world's conscience even against the powerful.

STEP 4: THE JUSTICE OWED, THE COMPACT & THE DOME — HOLDING THE POWERFUL TO ACCOUNT

Set expectations honestly: the levers are real but constrained by dependence on the responsible party, so the prize is justice pressed and partly won, not a swift full reckoning.

The Debt of Justice and the Compact Leverage

The distinctive lever is the **documented debt of justice** — the unpaid compensation, the unaddressed harm — a claim the world recognises. And the **Compact of Free Association** is both dependence and leverage: the strategic value the nation provides makes the compact's terms and renewals a genuine point of pressure. Press the debt through the compact.

The Dome and the Double Injustice

The **leaking Tomb** on Runit is a concrete, visible accountability the world can see and the responsible party must answer, and the **meeting of the nuclear and climate injustice** is uniquely powerful — a nation wronged by weapons and by a warming it did not cause. Make the dome the visible proof and the double injustice the moral force.

International Law and the World's Movements

International law and the world's movements — the courts, the human-rights and environmental regimes, the climate negotiations, the global public — stand with the wronged. Pursued together — the debt and compact, the dome and double injustice, and international law — these levers make the injustice a claim the world cannot ignore, and hold even the powerful to account.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case to each audience. **For the United States and its Congress:** here is a documented debt, unpaid, and a leaking dome you must answer. **For the compact negotiations:** here is the nation's strategic value, and the justice its terms should reflect. **For international law and bodies:** here is a wrong that engages your regimes. **For the climate negotiations:** here is a nation wronged twice, by weapons and by warming. **For the world:** here is the Tomb, and the double injustice it embodies. **The golden rule:** turn the documented injustice into a claim the world hears, use the compact as leverage, make the dome and the double injustice the moral force, and hold the powerful to account before the world's conscience.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and the world's conscience are central to this struggle. Frame the story around **the double injustice**: a small nation wronged by nuclear weapons and now by a warming it did not cause, its people displaced, its compensation unpaid, its Tomb leaking into the rising sea. Carry it through the international press, the human-rights and climate movements, and the global public. A few cautions: keep it accurate and grounded in the documented record; centre the affected communities' own voices; connect the nuclear and climate wrongs; and let the leaking Tomb and the debt owed carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message factual, grounded in the documented injustice, and pitched to the world's conscience.

8A — To the United States government or Congress: set out the unpaid debt and the leaking dome, and demand the accountability owed.

8B — On the compact: press the nation's strategic value and the justice its terms should reflect.

8C — To an international legal or human-rights body: present the documented wrong that engages your regime.

8D — To the climate negotiations: set out the double injustice of a nation wronged by weapons and warming.

8E — On the dome: document the leaking Tomb and the rising seas that threaten it.

8F — To the world's movements and public: share the injustice and ask the global conscience to stand with the wronged.

8G — To the nation's negotiators: coordinate the compact leverage and the justice claim.

8H — On a domestic harm: invoke the nation's own environmental assessment and marine or conservation designations.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: assemble the documented injustice — the unpaid compensation, the leaking dome, the contaminated islands; write the one-page claim tying the nuclear and climate wrongs. **The fastest-moving levers:** the documented debt, the dome accountability, and the world's conscience. **Emergency action:** where the compact is being negotiated or the dome is in the news, the leverage and the visible accountability are sharpest — press them before the responsible party and the world. Throughout, centre the affected communities and the double injustice.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is tilted by dependence on the very power responsible, which treats the matter as settled. Recognise it, and lean on the levers the tilt cannot erase — the documented debt the world recognises, the compact leverage the nation's strategic value provides, the leaking dome the world can see, and the uniquely powerful double injustice. Backed by international law and the world's movements, a wronged nation can hold even the powerful to account. And accept, honestly, that the leverage is constrained by dependence, that the responsible party resists, and that justice is unfinished — so the struggle is patient, and pitched to the world's conscience.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL INJUSTICE — AND WHO BENEFITS

Here the injustice is not hidden corruption but a documented historical wrong left unremedied, and a responsible party that treats it as settled while the harm endures. Respond through the channels that hold the powerful to account: the documented debt, the compact leverage, the dome accountability, international law, and the world's movements. **On safety:** the Marshall Islands is a peaceful democracy, so this struggle is open, lawful, and pitched to the world; the risk is not physical but the risk that a wronged small nation's claim goes unheard against a powerful ally it depends on. So make the injustice undeniable and the world's conscience the ally, and — for domestic harms — use the nation's own democratic and environmental tools.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The steps run in parallel. The documented injustice feeds the compact leverage, the international claim, and the world's-conscience campaign at once; the affected communities and the nation's negotiators press together; the media carries the double injustice throughout. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, assemble the documented injustice and the claim; **months and years two onward**, press the debt and the dome through the compact negotiations, international law, and the climate negotiations, and rally the world's movements; **through the long struggle**, keep the injustice a claim the world cannot ignore. The core discipline: injustice-documented, compact-leveraged, and pitched to the world's conscience.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

The Marshall Islands faces a struggle unlike almost any other in this guide, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim full justice can be swiftly won from a powerful ally that treats the matter as settled, or that the leverage is unconstrained by dependence, or that the harm and the climate threat are within the nation's control — none of that is true, and justice is unfinished. What it claims is real: that the documented debt of justice — the unpaid compensation, the contaminated homelands — is a claim the world recognises; that the Compact of Free Association is both dependence and leverage; that the leaking Tomb is a concrete accountability the world can see; that the meeting of the nuclear and climate injustice is uniquely powerful; and that international law and the world's movements stand with the wronged. The levers work through justice, the compact, and the world's conscience, and the prize is the debt pressed and partly paid, the dome held to account, the double injustice made undeniable — not a swift full reckoning. For a small nation wronged by a great power and now by a warming it did not cause, that patient work — turning injustice into a claim the world hears — is not a lesser ambition. It is how the powerful are held to account.